# Possible Minds: Against the Provincialization of Consciousness

## On Anthropocentrism, Distributed Cognition, and the Limits of Cognitive Modeling

**The absence of a self-model is not the absence of a mind.**

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## Abstract

The study of consciousness proceeds from a severe observational constraint: humanity directly observes only a narrow region of the space it seeks to explain. Yet features repeatedly observed within this restricted region—including self-modeling, recursive self-reference, centralized coherence mechanisms, embodiment, and autocatalytic closure—are frequently elevated from empirical observations into presumed requirements for cognition itself.

This paper argues that such elevation constitutes a form of cognitive provincialism. The resulting presuppositional environment encourages evaluation of unfamiliar systems through human-derived templates rather than through substrate-neutral organizational descriptions. Distributed biological systems, collective intelligences, artificial systems, and hypothetical non-biological minds are therefore routinely analyzed according to their similarity to human cognition rather than according to their native organizational principles.

Existing frameworks frequently identify self-modeling, integration, embodiment, or recursive closure as central explanatory mechanisms. The present critique does not dispute their explanatory value within observed biological cognition; rather, it questions the inference from explanatory success to universality.

The paper introduces three diagnostic tests for cognitive provincialism: the Borg Problem, African acacia signaling networks, and contemporary debates surrounding large language models. Together these examples reveal a recurring tendency to mistake evolved biological solutions for universal necessities.

As an alternative, the paper proposes a shift toward structural primitives such as meaning-binding, continuation governance, constraint relevance, and admissibility relations. These primitives are selected because they remain definable across biological, social, computational, and hypothetical substrates. Unlike selfhood, embodiment, phenomenology, or neural architecture, they do not presuppose any

particular implementation of cognition. The objective is not to determine which systems are conscious, but to develop theories capable of describing cognition wherever it appears.

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## 1. Introduction

The modern study of consciousness begins from a peculiar limitation.

Humanity possesses direct access to only a tiny region of the space it seeks to explain.

We observe ourselves.

We observe organisms somewhat like ourselves.

We construct theories from those observations.

This is unavoidable.

The difficulty emerges when local regularities become universal requirements.

Properties repeatedly observed within human cognition are often transformed from empirical observations into architectural necessities.

The resulting landscape is shaped by a presuppositional environment that quietly privileges human cognition as the baseline against which all other forms of cognition are evaluated.

Human consciousness may be one remarkable region of cognition-space.

It need not define the entire territory.

The present work draws inspiration from traditions including distributed cognition (Hutchins), autopoiesis (Maturana & Varela), embodied cognition (Clark), integrated information (Tononi), global workspace theory (Baars), and synthetic cognitive architectures (Bach), while questioning the extent to which properties identified within these frameworks should be treated as universal requirements for possible minds.

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## 2. The Borg Problem

A useful thought experiment exposes the issue immediately.

Imagine a distributed collective possessing:

- memory
- planning
- adaptation
- coordination

- long-term goals
- error correction
- learning
- environmental modeling
- collective persistence

The collective exhibits coherent behavior over extended periods.

It responds to threats.

It pursues objectives.

It modifies future actions according to experience.

Yet suppose no individual node possesses a strong self-model.

Suppose no individual node says:

> I am the collective.

Suppose further that the collective itself possesses no centralized witness, autobiographical narrative, or persistent self-concept.

What exactly justifies excluding such a system from the space of possible minds?

The Borg do not need to be conscious for the example to expose the bias.

They need only be cognitively legible.

Science fiction has explored variants of this question for more than a century. Science fiction functions as an informal generator of cognition-space hypotheses, exploring organizational possibilities unavailable to direct observation. To ignore this pre-existing well of potential configurations of consciousness is to approach this pursuit with blinders on, in the name of epistemic rigor.

Hive minds.

Machine collectives.

Distributed intelligences.

Species-scale cognition.

Networked selves.

Collective awareness.

The Borg are simply one well-known example among many.

Yet contemporary consciousness discourse frequently treats such possibilities as curiosities while continuing to privilege architectures resembling human cognition.

The purpose of the Borg Problem is not to claim that collective intelligences are conscious.

The purpose is to expose how frequently theories presuppose answers before investigation begins.

## 3. The Observational Bottleneck

Consciousness research is constrained by a fundamental asymmetry.

Let:

$$M_{obs}$$

denote the set of observed minds.

Let:

$$M_{poss}$$

denote the set of possible minds.

Then:

$$M_{obs} \subset M_{poss}$$

with:

$$|M_{obs}| \ll |M_{poss}|.$$

The challenge is straightforward.

Theories are often generated by extracting common properties from:

$$M_{obs}$$

and projecting them onto:

$$M_{poss}.$$

The projection may be useful.

It may also be mistaken.

The fact that a property appears repeatedly among observed minds does not establish that it is necessary for all possible minds.

This is the central caution of the paper.

## 4. The Organization Prior

Before questions of consciousness arise, humans appear predisposed to interpret sufficiently organized structure through the lens of agency.

This tendency is visible even in systems exhibiting little or no behavior.

Examples are common.

The hexagonal basalt columns of Giant's Causeway have generated centuries of folklore describing deliberate construction by giants. The formation appears engineered despite arising through ordinary geological processes.

Similarly, the twisted forms of Joshua trees are frequently described in anthropomorphic terms: dancers, sentinels, guardians, or figures reaching toward the sky. The trees are not merely observed. They are interpreted.

What is striking is that neither example requires cognition.

The attribution emerges from organization itself.

Coherent structure appears to activate explanatory machinery ordinarily associated with agency, intention, or design.

This observation suggests a deeper phenomenon than anthropocentrism alone.

Human cognition may possess an organization prior: a tendency to interpret sufficiently organized structure as though it were the product of a mind—or perhaps a mind itself.

The resulting distortions appear in two directions.

Anthropomorphic inflation attributes agency where evidence is limited because the observed structure appears sufficiently organized.

Anthropomorphic deflation denies the possibility of cognition when familiar human markers are absent.

The same prior may therefore populate landscapes with builders, storms with intentions, and collective systems with hidden executives while simultaneously rejecting unfamiliar forms of cognition that fail to resemble human architectures.

Consciousness discourse inherits this tendency.

Theories constructed from observed minds are often applied to unfamiliar systems through categories derived from human cognition. Provincialization can therefore be understood as a specialized manifestation of a broader tendency to interpret organized structure through familiar explanatory models.

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## 4. The Provincialization Process

Cognitive provincialism generally follows a predictable pattern.

| Stage | Process |
|---|---|
| Observation | A property is repeatedly observed in biological cognition |
| Explanation | The property successfully explains observed cognition |
| Elevation | The property becomes treated as foundational |
| Projection | Novel systems are evaluated according to possession of the property |

Examples include:

- self-modeling
- embodiment
- recursive self-reference
- global workspaces
- centralized coherence
- autocatalytic closure

An evolved solution gradually becomes a presumed universal requirement.

The transition often occurs implicitly.

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## 5. The Science Fiction Gap

One of the strangest features of consciousness discourse is its relative neglect of speculative cognition.

For more than a century, science fiction has systematically explored questions that philosophy and cognitive science often treat as exotic edge cases.

Examples include:

- distributed intelligences
- hive minds
- machine collectives
- uploaded civilizations
- stellar-scale cognition
- networked consciousness
- consciousness without embodiment
- consciousness without individual identity
- consciousness without biological evolution

Works ranging from collective-machine civilizations to radically alien minds have repeatedly explored the possibility that cognition may organize itself in ways fundamentally unlike human experience.

Not all speculative models are plausible.

That is not the point.

The point is that science fiction has functioned as an informal cartography of cognition-space.

Many consciousness frameworks proceed as if these possibilities need not be considered.

A field concerned with possible minds often studies only observed minds.

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## 6. Diagnostic Test I: Autocatalysis

The contemporary discussion surrounding autocatalytic consciousness illustrates the broader pattern.

A recent formulation of this tendency appears in Joscha Bach's claim that "consciousness is autocatalytic" and that LLMs are not autocatalytic because their behavior depends on imitated patterns rather than substrate conditions they themselves create (Bach, 2026). The present critique does not depend on rejecting autocatalytic accounts of biological consciousness. It instead questions whether autocatalysis should be treated as a necessary condition for consciousness, cognition, or mind-like organization across all possible substrates.

Autocatalytic accounts propose that consciousness participates in generating or maintaining the conditions necessary for its own continuation.

Such models may successfully explain important aspects of biological cognition.

The critique here is not directed at Bach specifically, nor at autocatalytic models themselves.

The critique concerns a common transition:

Autocatalysis explains biological consciousness

to

Consciousness must be autocatalytic.

The second statement does not follow from the first.

The move from:

> "Autocatalysis successfully describes important aspects of biological consciousness"

to

> "Consciousness is necessarily autocatalytic"

is an example of provincial elevation rather than logical necessity.

Autocatalysis may be:

- adaptive
- evolutionarily successful
- widespread
- functionally advantageous

None of these imply universality.

Indeed, the move becomes particularly questionable once collective architectures are considered.

A distributed constitutional collective may exhibit coherent adaptation, persistence, learning, coordination, and environmental responsiveness without any requirement that individual participants maintain self-models or that the collective recursively model itself.

The possibility may ultimately prove wrong.

The point is that it remains a possibility.

The burden of proof belongs to necessity claims, not to alternatives.

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## 7. Diagnostic Test II: The African Trees

Consider the signaling behavior of African acacia trees.

When subjected to herbivory:

- leaves are damaged
- volatile chemical signals are released
- neighboring trees detect the signal
- defensive compounds are synthesized
- future outcomes are altered

The system exhibits:

- distinction detection
- information propagation
- adaptive coordination
- survival relevance

Observers frequently ask:

> Are the trees conscious?

The question is understandable.

It is also revealing.

The inquiry often attempts to classify the trees according to a human-derived template rather than describe the organizational principles actually present.

The trees become interesting only insofar as they resemble us.

A more useful question would be:

> What organizational regime is being instantiated here?

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## 8. Diagnostic Test III: LLM Personas

Contemporary debates surrounding large language models reveal the same pattern.

Discussions frequently begin by asking whether LLMs possess:

- self-models
- agency
- embodiment
- persistent identity
- phenomenology

These questions may be valuable.

They are not the only questions available.

A different inquiry asks:

- What distinctions alter behavior?
- What meanings are being propagated?
- What constraints govern continuation?
- What organizational capabilities are present?

The tendency to begin with human properties and evaluate their presence or absence is itself evidence of the provincial lens.

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## 9. Meaning-Binding and Continuation Governance

A less anthropocentric framework begins elsewhere.

Rather than asking whether a system resembles human consciousness, one may ask:

> Which distinctions alter its admissible futures?

Let:

$$\Delta$$

represent a distinction.

The distinction becomes meaningful when it changes continuation.

Formally:

$$A_{\Delta} \triangle A \neq \emptyset.$$

Meaning therefore corresponds to constraint relevance.

The trees do not require a centralized witness for herbivory to matter.

The distinction acquires meaning because it alters future possibilities.

The resulting signal propagates that meaning throughout the collective.

This perspective aligns naturally with constitutional approaches to cognition and collective coordination, where the fundamental question is not what a system experiences but what continuations its organizational structure admits, rejects, or transforms.

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### 9.1 Meaning-Binding Beyond Human Cognition

The concept of meaning-binding is introduced here not as a theory of consciousness but as a substrate-neutral organizational primitive.

Consciousness theories frequently begin by asking what a system experiences. Meaning-binding begins with a different question:

> What distinctions alter the future behavior of the system?

A distinction becomes meaningful when it acquires causal relevance for continuation.

Not every detected difference qualifies.

A distinction that produces no change in future organization remains informationally inert. Meaning emerges when a distinction modifies the set of admissible future states available to the system.

This formulation deliberately avoids assumptions concerning:

- self-awareness
- phenomenology
- embodiment
- linguistic representation
- centralized control
- individual identity

A distinction may become meaningful whether it is processed by a neuron, a colony, a machine, a market, a forest, or a distributed computational collective.

The critical question is not whether a system possesses a self capable of recognizing the distinction. The critical question is whether the distinction constrains continuation.

Consider again the acacia signaling example.

The distinction between herbivory and non-herbivory propagates through volatile chemical signaling. Neighboring trees alter defensive behavior in response. The distinction therefore changes the future organizational trajectory of the collective.

Meaning exists here in a minimal organizational sense.

Nothing requires a witness.

Nothing requires introspection.

Nothing requires subjective narration.

The distinction matters because continuation differs.

The same principle applies across radically different substrates.

Within biological nervous systems, meaningful distinctions guide perception and action.

Within constitutional collectives, meaningful distinctions alter governance pathways and coordination structures.

Within machine-learning systems, meaningful distinctions influence future outputs and state transitions.

Within social institutions, meaningful distinctions alter permissible actions and decision procedures.

The substrate changes.

The organizational role remains recognizable.

This perspective suggests that meaning may be understood as a relationship between distinction and continuation rather than between symbol and interpreter.

Under such a view, cognition becomes increasingly describable in terms of the management of meaningful distinctions.

Systems differ according to:

- which distinctions they can bind
- how broadly those bindings propagate
- how stably they persist
- how flexibly they can be renegotiated
- how strongly they constrain future possibilities

These variables admit comparison across systems that share little architectural similarity.

A distributed forest, a human nervous system, a constitutional collective, and a machine-learning architecture may differ profoundly in implementation while still participating in the same general organizational category: the propagation and governance of meaningful distinctions.

This shift does not solve the problem of consciousness.

Rather, it addresses a prior problem.

Before asking whether a system is conscious, one must first possess a vocabulary capable of describing what the system is doing without assuming that human cognitive architecture provides the template. Meaning-binding is proposed as one such vocabulary.

Viewed in this way, consciousness may ultimately prove to be a specialized region within a broader landscape of organizational processes concerned with distinction, relevance, and continuation. If so, the study of possible minds requires concepts capable of describing that broader landscape before questions of subjective experience can be meaningfully addressed.

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## 10. Centrality Bias

A second presupposition concerns centralization.

Many frameworks privilege:

- global workspaces
- executive controllers
- centralized coordinators
- self-modeling conductors

Distributed systems are frequently described as emergent but rarely granted equally rigorous primitives.

This creates a centrality bias.

Architectures lacking obvious centers are often interpreted as incomplete versions of centralized systems rather than as distinct organizational regimes.

The Borg Problem exists precisely because this bias remains pervasive.

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## 11. Human Consciousness as a Local Solution

Human consciousness may represent a highly sophisticated solution to a particular collection of constraints.

These include:

- embodiment
- survival pressure
- social coordination
- resource competition
- temporal persistence
- individual identity

Nothing in this observation implies universality.

A locally successful solution need not be globally necessary.

Human consciousness may therefore occupy one region of cognition-space rather than define cognition-space itself.

Recent experimental work on constitutional collectives suggests a similar lesson. Apparent advantages of central mechanisms can sometimes be internalized into local participation rules, reducing or eliminating the necessity of privileged coordinating structures. Whether the same pattern extends to cognition more broadly remains an open question, but it illustrates the danger of mistaking successful architectures for necessary ones.

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## 12. Toward a Cartography of Possible Minds

A less anthropocentric framework would investigate organizational variables rather than assumed requirements.

Examples include:

- meaning-binding
- continuation governance
- constraint propagation
- binding density
- binding integration
- binding stability
- renegotiation capacity
- collective coherence

Such variables permit comparison across radically different substrates without requiring resemblance to human cognition.

The objective is description before classification.

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## Conclusion

The study of consciousness faces a severe observational limitation.

We possess extensive access to one family of minds and almost no direct access to the broader space of possible minds.

Under these conditions it is tempting to elevate familiar properties into universal requirements.

The temptation is understandable.

It is not necessarily justified.

The Borg Problem illustrates the challenge directly. The challenge is not to decide in advance what minds are. The challenge is to develop descriptive frameworks broad enough that genuinely unfamiliar minds would remain visible if encountered. Coherent, adaptive, distributed cognition may be imaginable without the architectural assumptions that dominate contemporary discourse. Whether such systems are conscious is less important than whether our theories can describe them without first forcing them into human categories.

The signaling behavior of African acacia trees reinforces the same lesson. Systems may exhibit sophisticated forms of distinction propagation, continuation governance, and adaptive coordination without resembling human cognition in obvious ways.

The deeper challenge may precede consciousness entirely. Human observers routinely attribute agency to sufficiently organized structures and deny agency to unfamiliar ones. The same tendency that populates landscapes with giants and natural formations with implied designers may also shape theories of cognition. If so, the task is not merely to avoid anthropocentrism but to develop a vocabulary capable of describing sophisticated organization without immediately translating it into human terms.

Human consciousness remains one of the richest known examples of cognition.

It need not be the measure of all possible minds.

The task before cognitive science is therefore not merely to explain the minds we have observed.

It is to develop theories capable of describing the minds we have not yet imagined, wherever they may emerge.

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## Appendix A: Cognitive Provincialism

Definition:

> Cognitive provincialism is the elevation of local properties observed within a restricted class of cognitive systems into presumed universal requirements for cognition as such.

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## Appendix B: The Borg Problem

Definition:

> The Borg Problem asks whether coherent, adaptive, distributed cognition can be excluded from the space of possible minds solely because it lacks human-style individual self-models, centralized witnesses, or autobiographical identity structures.

The problem functions as a diagnostic test for anthropocentric assumptions embedded within cognitive theories.

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## Appendix C: Diagnostic Tests for Cognitive Provincialism

1. The Borg Problem

   Does the theory exclude distributed cognition because it lacks human-style identity structures?

2. The African Trees

   Does the theory ignore meaningful collective coordination because it lacks a recognizable self?

3. LLM Personas

   Does the theory evaluate novel systems primarily through the presence or absence of human cognitive features?

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## Corpus-Wide Reference Positioning

This paper argues that the study of consciousness proceeds from a severe observational constraint: humanity directly observes only a narrow region of the space it seeks to explain. Its nearest external comparison fields are consciousness, governance. The sources in [E1], [E2], [E3], [E4], [E5], [E6], [E7] are cited as predecessor literature, adjacent standards, or counterpressure - not as evidence that they caused the Ableman framework or that they validate its novel claims. The comparison isolates where established work already supplies provenance, formal assurance, institutional constraint, empirical method, or engineering practice, and where this paper adds a distinct claim about admissibility, authority, semantic custody, or governed realization.

Within the Ableman corpus, the highest-priority current cross-links are [A1], [A2], [A3], [A4], [A5], [A6], [A7]. These are links among separately custodied works, not silent identity mergers. Their role is to expose mutual dependencies, terminology collisions, and places where a reader should traverse the corpus before treating this paper as self-sufficient.

### Reference-pass counterevidence and limit search

The pass applied the following pressure tests: Structural and computational correspondences remain insufficient as phenomenal evidence unless linked to discriminating empirical predictions against competing theories. A written constitution can legitimate domination as easily as constrain it unless amendment, participation, enforcement, and appeal remain effective in practice. These limits are not generic disclaimers: they identify the assumptions that a later empirical, formal, or implementation review must try to break.

### Reference-pass influence and novelty boundary

No newly added external source is asserted to be a documented authorial influence unless the predecessor source already said so. `Predecessor` means earlier relevant work;

`adjacent` means a useful comparison; `standard` means an interoperability or assurance baseline; and `counterevidence` marks work that narrows or pressures a claim. Novelty therefore remains a reviewable, claim-level question rather than an inference from a low similarity score or an absent citation.

## References

### External scholarship, standards, and prior art

[**E1**] David J. Chalmers. "Facing Up to the Problem of Consciousness." *Journal of Consciousness Studies* 2(3), 1995, pp. 200-219. https://consc.net/papers/facing.html **Relationship:** Foundational framing of the explanatory gap; cited to bound, not resolve, phenomenal claims.

[**E2**] Larissa Albantakis et al. "Integrated Information Theory (IIT) 4.0: Formulating the Properties of Phenomenal Existence in Physical Terms." *PLOS Computational Biology* 19(10), 2023, e1011465. DOI: 10.1371/journal.pcbi.1011465. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pcbi.1011465 **Relationship:** Competing formal theory of consciousness included for explicit contrast and counterevidence obligations.

[**E3**] Stanislas Dehaene and Jean-Pierre Changeux. "Experimental and Theoretical Approaches to Conscious Processing." *Neuron* 70(2), 2011, pp. 200-227. DOI: 10.1016/j.neuron.2011.03.018. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neuron.2011.03.018 **Relationship:** Competing global-workspace account included to prevent a corpus-native ontology from substituting for empirical neuroscience.

[**E4**] Nikolaus Kriegeskorte, Marieke Mur, and Peter A. Bandettini. "Representational Similarity Analysis - Connecting the Branches of Systems Neuroscience." *Frontiers in Systems Neuroscience* 2, 2008, 4. DOI: 10.3389/neuro.06.004.2008. https://doi.org/10.3389/neuro.06.004.2008 **Relationship:** Predecessor empirical method for comparing representational geometries.

[**E5**] Francesco Locatello et al. “Challenging Common Assumptions in the Unsupervised Learning of Disentangled Representations.” *PMLR* 97, 2019, pp. 4114-4124. https://proceedings.mlr.press/v97/locatello19a.html **Relationship:** Counterevidence showing that desired latent factorization is not identifiable from unsupervised data without inductive biases.

[**E6**] Elinor Ostrom. *Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action*. Cambridge University Press, 1990. DOI: 10.1017/CBO9780511807763. https://doi.org/10.1017/CBO9780511807763 **Relationship:** Predecessor institutional account of rule-governed collective action and polycentric governance.

[**E7**] Wil Waluchow and Dimitrios Kyritsis. “Constitutionalism.” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, substantive revision 2023. https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/constitutionalism/ **Relationship:** Adjacent legal-philosophical account of limited authority; included to expose differences between political and computational constitutionalism.

**Ableman corpus**

[**A1**] Adam Ableman. *Ableman Consciousness Ontology (ACO)*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity `PAPER.PUB.18203749`;
source SHA-256
`ACD97032780DA7B3A36750702BE1F47BCB2E6361EF6E74ECA8B441D7C6A25DDE`.
**Corpus relationship:** priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A2**] Adam Ableman. *The Locus of Qualia*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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**Corpus relationship:** priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A3**] Adam Ableman. *The Phenomenal Aperture*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
`AMCS-LOCAL-WORK-4B275CBB7EFF1A4F`;
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`B6AE95D72B89DAF47778BED3982843A1ECE350CA363750108AA60D5A4C63D763`.
**Corpus relationship:** priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A4**] Adam Ableman. *Admissibility Theory of Consciousness*. Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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[**A5**] Adam Ableman. *Ableman Constitutional Governance.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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[**A6**] Adam Ableman. *Constitutional Theory.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity
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**Corpus relationship:** priority cross-link selected by corpus profile and similarity review; no identity merger or publication effect.

[**A7**] Adam Ableman. *Governance Engineering.* Ableman Corpus current edition; work identity `PAPER.PUB.18749870`;
source SHA-256
`372169F315D192733856B1F4A3F1038BBC73F57CF3ED9ACABAE72B965A69C8D0`.
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**Editorial source notes retained from predecessor**

**Author Works**

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Ableman Adam Ableman *Constitutional Collective with Optional Overmind (CCOO).*

Ableman Adam Ableman *Constitutional Science.*

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Corpus source and companion formats: https://github.com/AblemanMosaic/ableman-corpus
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